Many air warriors who ruled the skies must have overcome their first hurdles in this very place.

‘Good afternoon, candidates. I’m Squadron Leader Manoj Yadav and I’ll be coordinating the day’s events. If you’re done chatting, please get yourselves arranged in twenty-five rows of ten candidates each,’ Squadron Leader Manoj Yadav, a medium-built, fair-skinned officer with a sharp crew-cut hairstyle, dressed in a finely creased uniform, announced from the front of the crowd and the chit-chatting died away. Slowly, the girls shifted as per this young officer’s strict command, loud enough to have been heard by all of us. Many gawked at him in silence.

‘How handsome!’ Hema whispered in my ear. ‘God, please get me through the screening if he’s going to be our coordinating officer.’

‘If that’s where your focus is right now,’ I added, ‘you really need God’s help.’

‘I can’t think straight, Gunjan, I’m hungry.’

As we chuckled at Hema’s nonsensical correlation, the officer shifted his gaze and stared at us. Caught and confused, we tried to look away but it was too late.

‘What are you two so happy about?’ he asked plainly. Neither of us responded. ‘I’ll see which one of you is still smiling after the aptitude test is over.’

At lunch, I hardly ate, as compared to Hema. I wasn’t smiling when we entered the examination hall later in the afternoon. I just felt quiet and confused. I had not practised for the aptitude test. Papaji had told me it would be easy and that I was smart enough to make it through. But the nervousness inside the examination hall and on the face of fellow candidates had suddenly made this test a fearsome affair. I began to doubt myself. *But aptitude is only basic IQ, Gunjan*—Papaji’s words reverberated in my head. What made him think I was smart enough for this test? Was it a fair judgement or merely a father’s love for his little girl? Only the question paper would tell. And then I waited . . .

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